
Whatever You Do.

The Workbook

Sections two to four · to work through on paper

NAME

COACH

START DATE

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord.

Colossians 3:23

How to use this

This booklet covers the middle of the course, which works better on paper. At the end it will send you back online to finish.

☐	One · Your gifts and talents The card sort, the written questions, and what the people who know you said.	ONLINE
☐	Two · The shape of your life Mapping your story, and what has happened in each season of it.	THIS BOOKLET
☐	Three · Expressing your calling Narrowing it to a sentence, then opening it back up.	THIS BOOKLET
☐	Four · Your growth plan Turning all of it into something you will actually do.	THIS BOOKLET
☐	Five · Finishing Four closing questions, and a letter to yourself in a year's time.	ONLINE

THREE THINGS WORTH KNOWING

This is not a test. Nobody marks it and nobody else reads it unless you choose to show them. An honest half-answer is worth more than a tidy one.

It is meant to be unhurried. Three or four sittings of half an hour is better than one long evening. The thinking needs time to settle.

You are not meant to do it alone. There are three conversations with your coach built into this booklet. They matter more than any single page in it.

WHAT YOUR COACH IS FOR

A coach is not a mentor handing down their own experience. Their job is to ask questions and let you find your own answers. If they start telling you what they would do, it is entirely fair to point that out.

You will need a pen, a Bible, and somewhere you're unlikely to be interrupted. Your 'gifts and talents' results may not be fully complete, as it can take a while to get others to provide their assessments of you – don't let that stop you making progress on the workbook.

Twelve readings to work through as you go

These devotional materials are designed to provide the New Testament backdrop to your ongoing consideration of what Christian work and calling is.

They appear at each stage of the booklet, placed where they bear on the work you are about to do. For each of the twelve portions there is some commentary to frame the Bible verses, a quote from a Christian thinker, questions to reflect on, and suggested prayer points to get you started.

HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM THEM

Read them slowly. Read them multiple times. Pray through them. Underline bits, meditate on them. Memorise them, and write down what you sense the Holy Spirit might be saying to you as you do all of the above.

To keep this sustainable, we'd recommend you swap it out for your quiet times while doing this workbook, rather than treating it as additional material.

All Scripture is God-breathed and useful ... so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work. 2 Timothy 3:16-17

The Bible passages, by definition, are God speaking. Embrace His words, listen as attentively as you can.

AS YOU GO

1	Matthew 11: 28-30	Start from rest, not striving
2	Ephesians 2: 4-10	Made, and made for something
3	John 15: 1-16	Fruit comes from remaining
4	Matthew 25: 14-30	Stewarding what you were given
5	Matthew 16: 24&25	Losing your life to find it
6	Acts 4:13	Ordinary, and unmistakably his
7	Matthew 6:19-34	Treasure, and what you seek first
8	1 Peter 4:8-11; 1 Corinthians 10:31	Gifts, to be spent on other people
9	1 Thessalonians 4:9-12	A quiet life, and your own hands
10	Colossians 3:22-24; Ephesians 6:5-8	Working for the Lord, not for men
11	Matthew 5:13-16; Philippians 2:13--16	Salt, light, and the people you work with
12	Revelation 21:1-2, 22:1-2; 1 Corinthians 15:58	Nothing done in the Lord is wasted

Matthew 11: 28-30

Start from rest, not striving

As we begin a season of considering our 'work' and calling, let's start from a place of rest, not striving. At the heart of the gospel is the reality that **the work that matters far more than any other is the work of Jesus**. His grace means that work and calling aren't heavy obligations to tick off a list to please God.

Instead, they are an opportunity to experience what his 'easy yoke' and 'light burden' look like in our lives. Most of all, let's start by accepting Jesus' invitation - "Come to me" - draw near, spend time in my presence... "and I will give you rest". **To know our calling, we need to know the one who calls us.**

"You don't need to unburden or collect yourself and then come to Jesus. Your very burden is what qualifies you to come. No payment is required; he says, "I will give you rest." His rest is gift, not transaction. Whether you are actively working hard to crowbar your life into smoothness ("labour") or passively finding yourself weighed down by something outside your control ("heavy laden"), Jesus Christ's desire that you find rest, that you come in out of the storm, outstrips even your own."

— Dane C. Ortlund, *Gentle and Lowly: The Heart of Christ for Sinners and Sufferers*

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- 'Gentle', 'humble', the one who gives an 'easy yoke' and a 'light burden' - do you know Jesus to be like this?
- Is anything 'wearying' you? What 'burdens' are you carrying that aren't from God?
- What do practices of rest and sabbath look like in your life at the moment?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus! He is full of gentleness and humility, not a brutal taskmaster
- Repentance for areas of our lives where we are 'working' to earn God's approval, rather than serving Him out of gratitude
- Asking to experience Jesus' nearness and rest, at the start of this exploration of calling

Ephesians 2: 4-10

Made, and made for something

Many of us are deeply familiar with verses 4 to 9. They are rich, glorious and encouraging. Salvation through faith alone means we can't - and don't have to try to - strain and strive to 'make up for' our sins. And we're not 'just' saved - we are 'made alive', 'seated with heavenly places', and will experience 'the immeasurable riches of His grace'.

But far too often, we stop there, and don't read verse 10. We love God's rich mercy, His saving grace, His unearned gift of salvation towards us, and rightly so.

But the gospel is more than that. **The gospel is also that we are designed by a creator, and that He has made us for a purpose. That He has prepared things for us to do for Him. To work, not to earn His love or our salvation, but out of gratitude for what God has done,** and also in recognition that it's part of our design.

"Grace is not opposed to effort, it is opposed to earning"

— Dallas Willard, The Great Omission

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- In your daily life or weekly rhythms, how do you remind yourself of God's rich mercy, great love, grace in kindness towards you?
- When you reflect on being 'God's workmanship', do you have any ideas about what good works God has prepared for you to walk in?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship! Thank God the Father that He loved us when we were dead in our sins, for making us alive in Christ, for seating us in heavenly places, and everything else in this incredible passage
- Confessing any times where you've tried to earn God's approval
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to help you spot the specific ways in which you've been 'designed', and the specific 'good works that God has prepared beforehand' for you

READING 3 OF 12

John 15: 1-16

Fruit comes from remaining

As saved people - those who are 'clean' (verse 3) - we are called to bear (lasting) fruit. But **we only bear fruit if we abide in the vine - Jesus**. Our fruitfulness is based on the Father's gardening work. Cutting out dead wood, and pruning back fruitful branches to increase future yield, look similar to the untrained eye. Our role is to cooperate with these (potentially painful) processes, remaining in and showing His love, obeying His commands.

“Our patterns of work and rest reveal what we believe to be true about God and ourselves. God alone requires no limits on his activity. To rest is to acknowledge that we humans are limited by design. We are created for rest just as surely as we are created for labour. An inability or unwillingness to cease from our labours is a confession of unbelief, an admission that we view ourselves as creator and sustainer of our own universes.”

— Jen Wilkin, Ten Words to Live By: Delighting in and Doing What God Commands.

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- How 'connected' / 'rooted' in the vine are you at the moment? Why?
- What 'dead wood' is being cut out of your life? What good things are being 'pruned'?
- What do your rhythms of 'abiding' / 'remaining' in the vine look like?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus as the life-giver, the one who sustains us, and all things!
- Confess where you have tried to bear fruit on your own, away from the vine
- Ask the Holy Spirit to help you discern how you can be more rooted in Jesus, and - as a result - more fruitful

SECTION TWO

The shape of your life

God speaks to us about calling not just through gifting, but through your circumstances, the people around you, the things you've done that bear fruit, and your prayers.

This section maps the seasons of your life out, then overlays circumstances, people, fruit and prayer over the top. This allows common threads to become more visible.

Read these first

Psalm 139, especially v13–16	Your days were written before one of them came to be.
Esther 4, especially v14	For such a time as this — the right person in the right place.
Romans 5:3–5	What suffering produces, and in what order.
Proverbs 15:22	Why this is not a solitary exercise.
John 15:1-7, especially v16	Chosen and appointed, so that your fruit would last.

Nothing in your story is wasted — the open doors, the closed ones, the people, the suffering, the fruit. Look back and notice what God has been doing.

Write the things that struck you in the readings:

Map out the chapters of your story

Break your life into seasons. Start at birth and work forwards – childhood, school, training, jobs, moves, the big transitions. Rough is fine, the order is what matters, not dates or detail.

the season

a one line description of that season



Early
life



The season you are in now

If you're stuck, try asking where you were living, who you were spending time with, or what you were most interested in at that point.

SECTION TWO • STEP TWO

Lay your story over the top

Now go through your chapters and write out the key things that happened in each. Include things that a) were clearly very significant, b) things that you *know* pointed to your calling, and especially c) things that were both!

Next, mark each thing with one of the following letters so you can see the pattern later.

D	Open door	A context, a contact or an opportunity that opened up.
H	Hardship & loss	A hard season, a loss, a rejection, or a door that shut.
P	Person	Someone who shaped, affirmed or spoke into you.
F	Lasting fruit	Something you did that bore fruit which outlasted it.
L	God's leading	A scripture, a prayer, a burden, a sense of God speaking.
?	Not sure	Mark it anyway. You can work out what it was later.

TWO THINGS TO RESIST

Do not filter out the bad bits. The seasons you would rather skip are usually the ones carrying the most.

Do not only mark the big events. A sentence someone said to you in passing has changed more lives than most career decisions.

Marking your chapters

the season

key parts of your story

letter



Early
life



The season
you are in
now

SECTION TWO • STEP THREE

What threads do you notice?

Step back and read everything you've written as one story rather than a list of events. Jot down the threads, then come back to this page again after you've slept or had time to mull it, reflecting and writing some more.

Reading it as a whole, the threads I notice are:

LOOK ACROSS YOUR TIMELINE

What keeps recurring? What has God been saying consistently?

Which chapter has the most marks on it? Formative seasons tend to be crowded. It is often not the one you would have guessed.

Is there a chapter holding both H and F? Worth asking what the one produced in the other. Where did suffering produce fruit *later*?

Where do the P marks cluster? What was it about that season that made you open to people? Who shows up at the turning points?

Which letter appears least? Is that because there is nothing there, or because it is harder to see?

Do the F marks follow the D marks? Did the fruit come from the open doors, or from somewhere else entirely?

READING 5 OF 12

Matthew 16: 24&25 (NIV)

Losing your life to find it

There is a huge danger in thinking of 'calling' in terms of self-actualisation. This can look like us trying to 'find ourselves'. But our 'calling' is **not about us**. It's not about the best possible career for our mix of strengths and abilities. All Christian calling on some level is to self-denial, in light of what Jesus has done.

The best possible outcome from considering your calling as a Christian is finding a practical expression of the gospel in your everyday life that is of such significance for time and eternity, and such a strong fit with your God-given gifts, that it is worth giving your life to in sacrifice.

We are not finding ourselves - we are finding life in Jesus, and living accordingly.

"When Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die."

— Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *The Cost of Discipleship*

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- What are your motivations for doing this course?
- Are there any areas of genuine self-denial in your life today? What specific self-denial might result from you growing in your apprenticeship to Jesus?
- What sacrifices have you seen, or read about, other Christians making that have inspired you?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus! He is not asking us to do anything He hasn't already done - His was the ultimate calling, the ultimate sacrifice, and the ultimate reward (see Hebrews 12:2)
- Confessing any times where you've made work and/or calling about you
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to empower you for any sacrifices Jesus might be calling you to make, as part of general discipleship, or as a result of this course

READING 4 OF 12

Matthew 25: 14-30

Stewarding what you were given

Jesus has **an expectation that we will be fruitful**. We are to steward the talents we've been given, for His benefit. We're given different quantities of talent, and these come with differing levels of responsibility. We also know from other passages such as 1 Peter 4:10-11, 1 Cor. 12:4-5, Romans 12:4-6, and Ephesians 4:11-13, that the talents (or gifts) we're given are of differing types. It's possible to grow in our gifting / talents - **when we're 'faithful in a little', He will entrust us with an opportunity to be 'faithful with much'**.

“Waiting for the Lord means our action is essential, but His is decisive. The farmer must wait for the harvest. But no one works harder than the farmer.”

— Bryan Loritts, Letters to a Birmingham Jail

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- Do you have any ideas of what talents God has given you? Flick through the 'gift list' passages above for ideas. What might 'trading with' those talents look like in practice?
- Despite the importance of gifting, the biggest driver of the servants' fruitfulness wasn't the level or type of raw materials they were given, but their perception of, and relationship with, their master. Which of the servants' attitudes to God, and serving Him, are your own most like?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Every good thing we have is ultimately an unearned blessing from God. Thank Him!
- Confess areas where you sense your relationship with God being more like that of the third servant
- Ask for the Holy Spirit to reveal more of what Jesus' is like to you, and to begin to highlight how you might use your talents for His glory

Talking it through

Show your coach the timeline before you go any further. Give them this page, and then add to your timeline based on the conversation with them.

FOR THE COACH · ABOUT 60 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Helping them read their own story back, and notice the threads they are too close to see. You are not interpreting their life for them. You are asking, and then waiting.

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS TO ASK

- “Walk me through this. Which chapter was hardest to write down?”
- “Where do you see hardship and fruit sitting in the same season?”
- “Who shows up at the turning points, and what did they see in you?”
- “Which chapter do you think is the most pivotal to understanding your calling?”
- “What is missing from this timeline that you chose not to include initially?”

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Seasons of suffering are often where the clearest formation happened. Be gentle, and do not rush to make meaning of something still raw.

If a whole category is empty – no people, or no sense of God leading – that absence is worth asking about kindly.

AVOID Imposing your own reading of their story. Ask what they see before offering what you see.

To close, ask them what – if anything – they’d like to add to the sheet with their story on it.

SECTION THREE

Expressing your calling

First narrow everything you've learned about your calling so far down to a single sentence. Afterwards, we'll generate lots of different ideas about expressing it – the same calling could be lived out in far more ways than the two or three you may have already thought of.

Do not skip the second half. People can arrive at this section with one idea already in mind; the point of the lenses is to find out whether it survives contact with the alternatives.

Read these passages first

Matthew 28:18-20	The commission that sits over every calling.
Matthew 22:34-40	The two commandments everything else hangs on.
1 Corinthians 15:58	Your labour is not in vain.
Acts 18:1-4	Paul the tentmaker <i>and</i> preacher.
Psalms 37, especially v3-7	Patient trust in God's timing.

Your general calling is the great commission and the greatest commandments, and it is the same as every other Christian's. Your specific calling works inside that — it is about where and how, not whether.

Acts 4:13

Ordinary, and unmistakably His

Even if we are seen as 'common and uneducated', with very little talent, we can make a massive difference for the kingdom if we have 'been with Jesus'. Read 3:1-4:22 - Peter and John knew Jesus, had been filled with His Spirit, had spent time in His presence. This allowed them to exercise faith, see incredible healing, lead thousands to Jesus, and engage the highest-ranking people in society. In the world's eyes they had very little talent, but when combined with being in Jesus' presence, everything changed.

"I thank God for my handicaps for, through them, I have found myself, my work, and my God" — Helen Keller

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- What limitations and constraints affect you most?
- Where has your relationship with Jesus, and time spent with Him, given you an ability to overcome your limitations for His glory?
- How have your limitations and constraints revealed, shaped and focused the things you feel you may be called into?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship! He is infinite, all-sufficient, omnipotent, eternal - unlike us, He has no limitations
- Confessing where you have allowed your limitations to make you bitter toward God, or tried to operate beyond your own limitations in your own strength, not His
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to help you meet with Jesus, to 'be with' Him

Everything you have found so far

Before you write anything new, bring together everything you already have. Read it as one picture: what keeps showing up is the clue.

From your assessment: your strongest gifts and biggest weaknesses

Words used about you, especially by others

When you are most energised, in your words and theirs

The threads you noticed, combining the ‘open doors’, ‘hardship and loss’, ‘people’, ‘lasting fruit’ and ‘God’s leading’ categories

Narrow it to a sentence

Build it in three parts, in your own words. Nothing here is final.

God seems to have designed me to...

[What you do - the kind of contribution you make]

among...

[Who it's for - the people or place it's aimed at],

so that...

[What it brings about]

Now write it in your own words

This is the sentence you will keep coming back to, so make it sound like you rather than like a mission statement.

Why does this matter to God?

When you do this well, how does it give Him glory, extend His kingdom, or bring beauty, order or abundance?

Matthew 6:19-34

Treasure, and what you seek first

How we use our talents is hugely impacted by our motivations. We could choose to use them for our own ends, to serve money (or some other earthly reward) rather than God. But ultimately the gospel compels us to be motivated to 'seek first the kingdom', and to expend ourselves 'laying up treasure in heaven', rather than obsessing about food, clothing, possessions or other material wealth.

"The only 'Christian work' is good work, well done."

— Dorothy L. Sayers, *Why Work?*

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- In what areas of your life are you most tempted to follow 'money' (or some other man-made idol) rather than God?
- What does 'seeking first the kingdom and His righteousness' look like in your life currently? What might it look like going forward?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship - thanking the Father for knowing what our daily needs are, and providing them, like verses 25-32 remind us
- Confessing any areas of your life where you've not been 'seeking first the kingdom'
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to help you overcome any anxiety about the future

How many ways could this play out?

Each lens below is a different angle on *‘what could this actually look like in practice?’* Use these as prompts to populate the ‘Your Ideas’ sheet below.

HOW THIS WORKS

Quantity, not quality. You are looking for a volume and breadth of ideas, not ‘the right answer’. Aim for 15+ ideas across the six lenses.

Do not judge any of these yet. Impractical ideas are helping your thinking. You will narrow these down afterwards in a separate exercise.

One line each. If you dry up, change lenses rather than pushing harder at the same one.

Lens 1. Who it serves

Take the ‘calling sentence’ you wrote above, and picture it aimed at a different group of people.

Expressed toward the obvious group — and then toward the group nobody is serving.

Expressed toward the person you used to be, ten years ago.

Expressed toward the people you would find hardest to serve.

Expressed toward an age group you have never considered.

Lens 2. Where it happens

Take the ‘calling sentence’ you wrote above, and picture it lived out in a completely different setting.

Expressed inside a sector you know nothing about.

Expressed somewhere with no money, staff or infrastructure.

Expressed in a place where this is currently done badly.

Expressed in a school. A prison. A hospital. A pub.

Lens 3. How you do it

Take the ‘calling sentence’ you wrote above, and imagine playing a different role in expressing it.

Expressed by teaching others to do it, rather than doing it.

Expressed by building the tool or system that lets others do it.

Expressed by funding or resourcing people already doing it.

Expressed in writing or speaking rather than in practice.

Expressed by convening the people already doing it.

The remaining lenses

Lens 4. How big it is

Take the 'calling sentence' you wrote above, and picture it aimed at wildly different sizes.

- Expressed for exactly one person, done brilliantly.
- Expressed for a room of twelve.
- Expressed at the level of a whole organisation.
- Expressed across an entire profession or field.
- Expressed in a single Saturday – and then across a decade.

Lens 5. What carries it

Take the 'calling sentence' you wrote above, and picture it within a different structure: a job, a business, a volunteer role, a church.

- Expressed as your actual paid job.
- Expressed as a business someone would pay for.
- Expressed voluntarily, alongside a job that pays the bills.
- Expressed through your local church.
- Expressed by joining something that already exists.

Lens 6. What if...?

Take the 'calling sentence' you wrote above, and challenge your own assumptions about what this has to look like.

- What if you had ten years and no money worries?
- What if you could only give it two days a week?
- What if the thing you are worst at were required?
- What if you had to hand it to someone else in three years?
- What if nobody ever knew it was you?
- What would the boldest person you know do with your sentence?

If you are stuck, take two lenses at random and force them together. Odd pairings produce the ideas single prompts never do.

Your ideas

One line each. Write the lens number in the margin if it helps. When you have finished, go back and mark the ones with something in them.

1	☆	
2	☆	
3	☆	
4	☆	
5	☆	
6	☆	
7	☆	
8	☆	
9	☆	
10	☆	
11	☆	
12	☆	
13	☆	
14	☆	
15	☆	
16	☆	
17	☆	
18	☆	
19	☆	
20	☆	

Before you move on, check: is there a lens you avoided? The one you skipped could surprise you. Go back and give it two minutes.

Turn the best into expressions

Now bring the ideas together. An expression is a fuller picture than a one-liner — a short paragraph describing what that version of your calling would actually be. You might cover what you'd be doing, where you'd be doing it, how that would glorify God, how the bills would get paid, what a normal week might look like, the kind of people you'd be working alongside and so on.

Write two or three potential 'expressions' of your calling, perhaps combining multiple of the ideas you starred above.

EXPRESSION ONE

Give it a short name

EXPRESSION TWO

Give it a short name

EXPRESSION THREE

Give it a short name

EXPRESSION FOUR

Give it a short name

READING 8 OF 12

1 Peter 4:8-11; 1 Corinthians 10:31

Gifts, to be spent on other people

'Each has received a gift - use it', 'steward God's varied grace', 'use it to serve one another' 'that in everything God may be glorified'. Peter's list of giftings is the shortest in the bible - can you speak, can you serve? His directions are equally concise - **use them in God's power, and use them for His glory.**

Paul backs this up in 1 Corinthians 10, and makes it even more general - **whatever** you're doing, whether it's something within your gifting or calling or not, you can, and should, do it for God's glory.

"I do not consecrate myself to be a missionary or a preacher. I consecrate myself to God to do His will where I am, be it in school, office, or kitchen, or wherever He may, in His wisdom, send me."

— Watchman Nee, The Normal Christian Life

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- Do you consider doing the things you're good at as 'stewarding God's grace'? How does this change how you might think/feel/act?
- In what contexts do you find yourself having the opportunity to 'speak' at the moment? What about 'serving'?
- In practice, how can God be glorified in your 'speaking' / 'serving' / 'whatever you do'?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus - 'To Him belong glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen!'
- Confessing any times that come to mind where your work has resulted in your glory, not His
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to help you 'speak like an oracle of God' and 'serve with God's strength'

Testing them

Take your sentence and your expressions to your coach before you build a plan around them. Give them this page.

FOR THE COACH · ABOUT 60 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Pressure-testing the sentence, and making sure they have genuinely explored a range of different ways of expressing what they currently understand to be their calling before narrowing down options. Your job here is to widen the field, not to help them choose.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

“Read me the sentence. Does it sound like you, or like someone you think you should be?”

“Which of these ideas did you dismiss quickest, and why?”

“What would it cost you to pursue the one you starred?”

“Which of these could you start something toward within a month?”

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Statements that are all abstraction are hard to act on. Push gently for specificity.

Watch for a calling shaped entirely by what would impress others, or entirely by what feels safe.

AVOID Narrowing it for them. Your job is to widen the field and test the options, not to pick.

After the conversation – write down what, if anything, changed in your thinking:

READING 9 OF 12

1 Thessalonians 4:9-12

A quiet life, and your own hands

Using your talents for the glory of God doesn't have to be *flashy*. 'Working with your hands' would have been looked down on and disrespected by the gentile peoples of the time. Paul's desire for the Thessalonians - living quietly, minding their own business, walking properly before outsiders, not depending on others - aren't glamorous. **Jesus can use us to do incredible things, but our ambition should be deeply rooted in simple daily witness and humility.**

“Lord, help me to do great things as though they were little, since I do them with your power, and little things as though they were great, since I do them in your name!”

— Blaise Pascal

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- Living quietly, minding your own business, walking properly before outsiders, not depending on others - how are these going for you? Think about each in turn, and consider what they do, or should, look like in your life and context.
- There's a simplicity about the working life that Paul is sketching out for the Thessalonians here. Make a list of all the different aspects of your 'work' - paid or unpaid - at the moment. Are there any simplifications you could make, to place more focus on the things God may be calling you to?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship - thanking God that, although He is utterly infinite, his claims can be lived out in very simple ways. He isn't making us jump through hoops, or restricting access to His presence to just the clever or wealthy few
- Confessing and repenting of times where you have not been 'living quietly, minding your own business, walking properly before outsiders'
- Asking to be 'taught by God to love' others more deeply and sacrificially

SECTION FOUR

Your growth plan

All of this is worth very little if nothing changes in practice. This section turns what you have discovered into specific actions, and then places them across the next eighteen months. The aim is to create a plan on one page rather than a feeling that fades.

Read these first

Luke 14:25–33	Counting the cost before you begin.
1 Timothy 4, especially v14–15	Do not neglect your gift. Give yourself wholly to it.
Philippians 3:7–16	Not arrived, but pressing on.
Colossians 3:23–24	Whatever you do, and who you are ultimately working for.

A plan made in a moment of clarity rarely survives contact with an ordinary week. That is not a reason to skip it – it is a reason to make it smaller than you want to.

What needs to be in the plan

A good growth plan has five ingredients. Write specific, doable actions under each — one line per action. Two or three in each is plenty.

Taking steps

We learn by doing. Experiments clarify a calling faster than more thinking, so these usually come early.

What are you unsure about, and what could you actually try in order to find out?

Grow your gifting

Skills compound slowly. Start early and expect the payoff later in the plan.

How will you deepen what you already have, and add what you do not?

Character

The foundation everything else rests on. Begin now, and let it run throughout.

Which spiritual disciplines will you deepen in?

The last two

Mentorship

Mentors save you years. Ask early, so the relationship has time to bear fruit.

Who will you ask, and in what areas? Whose story do you want to hear?

Disciple others

Teaching others what you've learned cements your own growth.

Who could you help grow in something connected to your calling?

IF YOU ARE STUCK

Volunteer somewhere that tests this · shadow someone doing it for a day · take a course in a core skill · find a stretch project at work · establish a weekly rhythm of silence · join a small group for accountability · ask someone to meet monthly · interview three people about their calling · help one person a few steps behind you · teach a session on what you have learned.

Check before moving on. Is any of the five empty? A rounded plan usually touches all of them. If character and mentorship are blank, the rest tends not to last.

Colossians 3:22-24; Ephesians 6:5-8

Working for the Lord, not for men

These passages reframe how we think about earthly masters – 'working for the Lord rather than for people', 'the Master you are serving is Christ.' Our attitude should be wholehearted, sincere, and full of good will, with an eye not on our earthly paycheck but our eternal reward. In almost any work situation, however secular it feels, you can embed your faith into it by adopting this mindset. Christians are disciples, **apprentices of Jesus**. Through work experiences, we become more like Him; growing in gratitude, compassion, humility, perseverance, and generosity. So **whatever you do, Jesus is your boss**. Whether you feel called to the work or not, it should be done as if He is your line manager.

“When we work for Christ out of obligation, it feels like work. But when we truly love Christ, our work is a manifestation of that love, and it feels like love.”

— Francis Chan

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- How have 'work' experiences (perhaps including education) shaped you as a disciple of Jesus so far?
- In practice, who are your 'masters' at the moment? How does submitting to serving and obeying them feel at the moment?
- In what tangible ways does seeing Jesus as your primary boss change your daily life?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus! Thank Him for being interested in what goes on in your daily 'work' life. Thank Him that we will 'receive an inheritance as our reward' regardless of what our earthly paychecks look like
- Confessing where you've been rendering 'eye-service, as a people-pleaser' to your boss, doing whatever gets you an easy life rather than 'working heartily'
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to make His fruit (Galatians 5) more manifest in your life, particularly your interactions with your boss. Ask Him to make you more like Jesus, through – and for – your 'work' context

When will you do it?

Now place each action into one of the next six quarters (18 months). Aim for fewer things done well, a plan you can actually keep rather than one that looks impressive.

QUARTER	PLANNED ACTIONS
1 Months 1 - 3	
2 Months 4 - 6	
3 Months 7 - 9	
4 Months 10 - 12	
5 Months 13 - 15	

READING 11 OF 12

Matthew 5:13-16; Philippians 2:13--16*Salt, light, and the people you work with*

Christians can stand out at work as missionaries. It's often the context we spend the most time with people who don't follow Jesus. **Whatever our specific callings, we are all called to be salt and light in the world, bringing Jesus to those who don't know Him.** A missional lifestyle ('good works') is needed for our evangelism to be credible. Christians being 'salt and light' goes beyond merely engaging individuals with the gospel, vital though that is. This kind of 'cultural renewal' might be as narrow as helping make your workplace a context where people thrive, or as wide as serving society as a whole, especially the marginalised.

"The rapid growth of the Christianity in its first couple of centuries must often have been not from formal preaching, but informal chattering to friends and chance acquaintances, in homes and wine shops, on walks, and around market stalls. They went everywhere gossiping the gospel; they did it naturally, enthusiastically, and with the conviction of those who are not paid to say that sort of thing.... Until once again the task of evangelism is something which is seen as incumbent on every baptised Christian, and is backed up by a quality of living which outshines the best that unbelief can muster, we are unlikely to make much headway through techniques of evangelism."

— Michael Green

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- What parts of your life might make the gospel attractive to people you 'work' with?
- What does being 'salt and light' look like in your 'work' context? Are there specific people you are serving and caring for - not because they're some kind of conversion project - but out of genuine love? Have you shared your faith with some of them?
- Asking people questions to make them think about faith is often an effective way to begin to share some aspects of the gospel with them. What questions could you ask?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus! Thank Him we don't 'labour in vain', and that He is 'working in us'
- Confessing where you've 'grumbled and disputed' or not been 'blameless and innocent' at work
- Asking the Holy Spirit for opportunities to share your faith with those you work with

The first step

A plan without a date is a wish. But plans change, and that's ok. Fill this 'first step plan' in before you close the booklet, so you know you're clear on where to start.

The very first thing I will do

I will do it by

The person I will get to ask me whether I did it or not

FOR THE COACH · CONVERSATION FOUR · ABOUT 45 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Making the plan realistic, and agreeing how they will be held to it.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

“Which of these will actually happen, and which is wishful thinking?”

“What is the first thing, and when precisely will you do it?”

“What is most likely to derail this in the next six months?”

“Who else needs to know about this plan for it to survive?”

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Over-loaded quarters are the commonest failure. Two or three real commitments beat ten aspirations. Plans with no character or mentorship work in them tend not to last.

AVOID Ending without a specific date for the first step, and a date to review it together.

Revelation 21:1-2, 22:1-2; 1 Corinthians 15:58

Nothing done in the Lord is wasted

Adam and Eve were placed in Eden to release the undeveloped potential God had deposited in the Garden. They were to **fill the planet not just with humans, but with cultural flourishing**.

We can work this out from the end of the story. Ezekiel and Revelation end with descriptions of how God will remake a perfect world, at the end of history. The relationship between God and humans is restored; evil and its effects are destroyed. But in this re-created, perfect world, God and his people aren't back in a Garden of Eden. They live – and work – in a Garden City, a place of cultural flourishing. While teaching about the resurrection and the End Times, Paul tells the Corinthians that, in the Lord, 'our labour is not in vain'. **What we do now, however frustrated and imperfect, if it's done for Jesus, will be made worth it, it will be made new. Our work now points toward the Garden City.**

“Everyone will be forgotten, nothing we do will make any difference, and all good endeavours, even the best, will come to naught. Unless there is God. If the God of the Bible exists, and there is a True Reality beneath and behind this one, and this life is not the only life, then every good endeavour, even the simplest ones, pursued in response to God's calling, can matter forever.”

— Timothy Keller, Every Good Endeavour

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

- Think about what you're working on today – what bits of it might make it to the 'Garden City'? What might it look like when it's 'made new'?
- Given that from an eternal perspective no labour – in the Lord – is in vain, what would you attempt in this life, even if you knew you would 'fail'?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

- Worship Jesus! Thank Him that He is coming back, that He will make all things new, that he will wipe away every tear, and 'make every evil thing untrue'
- Confessing the areas of your life where you're living without an 'eternal perspective'
- Asking for the Holy Spirit to give you a vision for how you could contribute to 'cultural renewal', and the power to work toward that

FINISHING

Two things left, both online

You have done the paper part. There are two things left, and they are online for a reason.

ONE

The same five questions you answered at the start

You will not be shown your earlier answers until afterwards. That is deliberate, knowing would change what you put. Seeing the points together allows people realise how far they have come.

TWO

A letter to yourself, in a year's time

Write to the person who will be reading this in twelve months. Tell them what you have worked out, what you are afraid will happen, and what you want them to hold you to. Ask them a direct question.

It is sealed until then, and nobody else ever reads it.

BEFORE YOU PUT THIS DOWN

Date I finished the workbook

Date I went back online to finish

For we are his workmanship,
created in Christ Jesus
for good works,
which God prepared beforehand,
that we should walk in them.

Ephesians 2:10

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